

AN ARTIST AT HOME 'Temple Tank 2, Varkala' watercolour on paper (2022) by Shibu Natesan

a lot of planning, or a lot of waiting to get just the right angle of sunlight—but in reality, it was the exact opposite scenario.

"When I arrive at a place and I feel like I want to sketch or paint some part of it or some people who are there, I don't overthink the process," says Natesan. "It's more like a stream of consciousness; it's about allowing your instincts to take over. I may interact with a shopkeeper or a salesperson occasionally. Usually, they express an interest in being sketched, because in today's day and age, a travelling painter is something of a novelty, although it was very common during my formative years as an artist." You'd be well-advised to spend some quality time with these paintings. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

EXHIBITION ▼

Blessed Craft

In Celestial Company **at MAP, Bengaluru, draws from the museum's extensive collection of over 100,000 artefacts to spotlight the companions of Hindu deities**



This festive season, the Museum of Art & Photography (MAP), Bengaluru, invites visitors to step *In Celestial Company*, a captivating exhibition that brings to life the divine helpers, mythical creatures and wondrous attendants who accompany gods and goddesses through legend and ritual. On view until February 15, 2026, the show draws from MAP's extensive collection of over 100,000 artefacts. The exhibition invites viewers to reflect on how imagination, faith, and artistry have long intersected to shape the sacred imagery. Through its vibrant design and layered curation, the show celebrates India's artistic heritage and the universal appeal of its mythic imagination. Curated by Priya Chauhan, it turns the spotlight towards such creatures as Garuda, Nandi and Mooshika to the more enigmatic Apsaras, Kinnars and Gandharvas. Through sculptures, textiles, brass figurines, paintings, chariots and wooden artefacts, the display reveals how these hybrid beings embody transformation, devotion and symbolism that transcend cultural and religious boundaries.

> The exhibition shows how these beings, **half-human, half-divine,** are metaphors for the desire to connect with the divine

While deeply rooted in Indian mythology, *In Celestial Company* also acknowledges cross-cultural narratives—angels and colonial-era artefacts that testify to centuries of exchange and artistic reinterpretation.

Chauhan's curatorial approach illuminates how these beings, half-human and half-divine, serve as metaphors for the desire to connect with the sacred and the unknown.

The exhibition's design deepens engagement through interactive and inclusive experiences. A tactile book allows visitors with visual disabilities to explore the gallery layout and artworks, complemented by an audio guide. Those with hearing disabilities can access stories of the celestial beings via the Bloomberg Connects app. Families are invited to step into an immersive storytelling booth, offering a 360-degree audio-visual journey into the adventures of 'Garuda, the King of Birds'. For visitors, a beautifully designed foldout takeaway provides stories to carry home, a memento of their divine encounter.

By bringing these mythic beings "from the shadows to the light", MAP encourages visitors to rediscover the celestial fabric woven into India's collective imagination. The exhibition honours figures that lingered in the periphery and now command the spotlight—radiant, powerful and profoundly human in their divine purpose. ■

—Nikhil Sardana



WONDER FIGURES Top, a wooden figure of a Gandharva; right, an angel holding a fan depicting Kartikeya, in wood and metal